

All of us know, from experience, that something we cannot even see has changed us. That nothing is bigger. No community, no nation, no borders, no government. That something microscopic, which goes by the technical-sounding name SARS-CoV-2, could dwarf all else. A world that has seen and survived that may look no different from the outside, but the inner landscape of humanity has been transformed. We all act now with a much deeper sense of mortality: its presence is not something we can refuse to think about.

The time we have, now we know, is not a given—and it's evanescent. The ubiquity of death has brought about an overwhelming respect for the present moment. And people are responding to this new feeling, perhaps paradoxically, in extravagant ways. Call it a coping mechanism, but everyone is indulging their inner desires like there's no tomorrow—things they may have perennially deferred otherwise. Moving to a vocation after their heart, buying something of their fancy regardless of its cost, travelling to exotic locations, trying to eke out moments of pure joy, painting a silver lining to the greyest time we have seen. After all, You Only Live Once.

Arvind Ganga, a retired merchant navy officer based in Delhi, came to that realisation at the peak of the second wave as he saw death snatching his friends overnight. So he decided to travel...to Antarctica! When the 48-year-old stay-at-home dad came across the chance to go on his dream holiday—in the middle of the pandemic—he went right ahead and booked his ticket. As a sailor, the seas are not unknown to him. The thought had been breeding within, but the cost always seemed prohibitive. This time, though, he simply had to do the South Pole. Last December, he found a ship that offered a trip to the continent at half the usual price. Omicron had just come on the horizon, and as a highly infectious brand of Covid-19, it was not to be taken lightly. But Ganga and his three friends didn't cancel their tickets. Fortune favoured them and all borders remained open during their dates of travel. Theirs was the second, and last, ship of the season to visit Antarctica.

His words express sentiments that

SANKHADEEP MITRA, *46*

Former banker, ***Kolkata***

Dream fulfilled

Started his own photo gallery cum cafe, Zoom Tea-O-Graphy

How Covid changed me

"It was only when Covid struck and I saw death around me that I realised life was short, transient and had to be lived to the full"